context, might there have been hoots of laughter at the efforts on behalf of vegetarianism from distant Pataliputra?

The bones of domesticated sheep, goats, possibly cattle, red deer, gazelles, and horses have turned up in neolithic contexts.[38] Later, at the major urban centre of Mundigak, some 55 km north of Kandahar, material from the second millennium BCE exposes species ranging from domesticated animals like the ass, the horse, and the dog, to wild fauna. Apart from the ibex, the lynx, and the gazelle, the bones include those of a raptor.[39] It is likely that later too, in the first millennium BCE, this dietary pattern was maintained. So, whatever the claims of administrators on the success of Ashoka's policy of non-violence towards living beings, it is difficult to believe that vegetarianism took off here. Epigraphic announcements were listened to, not necessarily followed. People continued to carry on with their lives as before.

In some ways the Ashokan message here is really much larger than anything that the emperor intended. Looking at it now we understand that what the king said did not always define or even considerably influence the tenor of daily life. The populace will have seen some of these particular exhortations as most peculiar, and therefore taken them with a large pinch of salt.